

Chenyu Bu

Curriculum Vitae | May 2026

Department of Philosophy
University of Texas, Austin
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EDUCATION	University of Texas at Austin	2021 –
	Ph.D. in Philosophy (ABD) Dissertation: <i>Objects, Structures, and Abstraction</i> Committee: Kathleen Higgins (co-chair), Jon Litland (co-chair), Robbie Kubala, Josh Dever, James Buhler (Music)	
	University of Wisconsin–Madison	2017 – 2021
	B.A. in Philosophy, Music Composition, Mathematics <i>with Honors in the Liberal Arts</i>	
RESEARCH AREAS	AOS: Metaphysics, Aesthetics AOC: Philosophy of Mathematics, Philosophy of Language, Philosophy of Logic	
PUBLICATIONS	Peer-Reviewed Journal Articles	
	Music without Works: A Case for Compositional Ontology <i>The Philosophical Quarterly</i> (forthcoming).	2026
	Schopenhauerian Musical Formalism: Meaningfulness without Meaning <i>Journal of Comparative Literature and Aesthetics</i> 46 (4), 92-101.	2023
	Book Reviews	
	Daniel Albright, <i>Music's Monisms: Disarticulating Modernism</i> (2022) <i>The British Journal of Aesthetics</i> , 65 (4), 691-695	2024
	Tristan Grøtvedt Haze, <i>Meaning and Metaphysical Necessity</i> (2022) <i>Review of Metaphysics</i> 77 (2), 351-353.	2023
WORKS IN PROGRESS	A paper developing a general theory of generativism A paper arguing for a top-down structuralist approach to essences A paper reconciling platonist and creationist views of music A paper reconstructing a Hanslickian formalism A paper on higher-order generalizations of neutral relations	
SELECTED TALKS	Peer-Reviewed Conference Presentations Generating Structures: An Essentialist Account 2026 Henle Conference, St. Louis, MO How to Stop Worrying and Embrace Musical Platonism	March 2026

American Society for Aesthetics (ASA) Pacific Meeting, Berkeley, CA	March 2026
American Philosophical Association (APA) Pacific Meeting, Chicago, IL	April 2026
Beyond the Given: Toward a General Theory of Generativism	
APA Central Meeting, Chicago, IL	February 2026
Doing Away with Works: Let’s Talk About <i>Music</i>	
APA Central Meeting [virtual]	February 2025
Cohesion, Clarity, Closure: How Music Navigates the Wake of Tragedy	
Performance Philosophy Biennial Conference, Austin, TX	May 2024
Structuralism Made Simple via Morphisms	
uAnalytiCon Annual International Conference [virtual]	May 2024
Musical Formalism Reconsidered: A Category-Theoretic Approach	
ASA Eastern Meeting, Philadelphia, PA	April 2024
Music as Meaningfulness Without Meaning: A Schopenhauerian Account	
Jahrestagung der Schopenhauer-Forschungsstelle [virtual]	November 2023
UT-Austin Graduate Colloquia Series, Austin, TX	September 2022
In Defense of a Real Musical Platonism	
ASA Rocky Mountain Meeting, Santa Fe, NM	July 2023
An Inferentialist Account of <i>I</i>	
Society for Philosophy in the Contemporary World Annual Meeting, Fresno, CA	July 2023
Sound, Silence, and Sartrean Nothingness	
Boston College Dianoia Publication Symposium [virtual]	July 2020
Workshops	
Toward a General Theory of Generativism	
Metaphysical Mayhem, New Brunswick, NJ	May 2025
Abstract Object and Platonic Inheritance	
APA Eastern Meeting, New York, NY	January 2025
Commentaries	
Andrew Kania, “Justifying and Advancing the Explication of the Musical-Cover Concept,” ASA 83rd Annual Meeting, Baltimore, MD	October 2025
Matthew Shields, “The Impossibility of Conceptual Abandonment,” APA Central Meeting [virtual]	February 2025
Minseok Kim, “Way-Nominalism: An Ontological Ground for Non-Nominal Quantification,” APA Central Meeting, New Orleans, LA	February 2024
University Graduate Continuing Fellowship (UT Austin)	2025-26
Humanities Research Awards (The Humanities Institute)	2025-26
Billy Bob Draeger Graduate Research Fellowship in the Humanities	2024-25
Summer Graduate Fellowship (UT Austin)	2024
Professional Development Award (UT Austin)	2023, 2024

	Irene H. Chayes Travel Grant (ASA)	2023, 2024
	Best Graduate Student Essay Prize (Center for Philosophical Studies)	2023
	Summer Research Funds (UT Graduate Studies)	2023
	Top Paper of <i>Logos</i> Volume XVI (Cornell University)	2020
TEACHING EXPERIENCE	Instructor of Record at University of Texas at Austin	
	Philosophy and Film	Spring 2025
	Introduction to Philosophy of the Arts	Fall 2024
	Teaching Assistant at University of Texas at Austin	
	Introduction to Philosophy of the Arts (Matthew Bisconti)	Spring 2024
	Intermediate Symbolic Logic (Joshua Dever)	Fall 2024
	Introduction to Philosophy of the Arts (Kathleen Higgins)	Spring 2023
	Problems of Knowledge and Valuation (Mark Sainsbury)	Fall 2022
	Introduction to Philosophy of the Arts (Alicia Armijo)	Spring 2022
	Philosophy of Law (Jeffrey Leon)	Summer 2022
	Ideas of the Twentieth Century (Daniel Bonevac)	Fall 2021
SELECTED COURSEWORK	Graduate Seminars at University of Texas at Austin	
	Higher-Order Metaphysics (with Jon Litland and Harvey Lederman)	Fall 2025
	Issues in Philosophy of Music (with Kathleen Higgins)	Spring 2024
	Plenitude and Generation (with Jon Litland)	Fall 2023
	Artworks and Persons (with Robbie Kubala)	Fall 2023
	MSDRT Model Theory (with Hans Kamp)	Summer 2023
	Formal Epistemology (with Harvey Lederman)	Spring 2023
	Theories of Meaning (with Joshua Dever)	Spring 2023
	Kant's <i>Critique of Pure Reason</i> (with Ian Proops)	Spring 2023
	Logic and Inferentialism (with Jon Litland and Sinan Dogramaci)	Fall 2022
	<i>De Se</i> and the Self (with Joshua Dever and Miriam Schoenfield)	Fall 2022
	Perception and Action (with Galen Strawson)	Spring 2022
	Aesthetics (with Kathleen Higgins)	Fall 2021
	Metaethics and Aesthetics (with Karl Schafer and Robbie Kubala)	Fall 2021
	Conference Courses at University of Texas at Austin	
	Musical Structuralism and Category Theory (with Jon Litland)	Fall 2023
	Music and Meaning (with Kathleen Higgins)	Spring 2023
	Undergraduate Seminars at University of Wisconsin-Madison	
	Music, Capitalism, and Speculative Future (with Nadia Chana)	Spring 2021
	Renaissance Polyphony (with Leslie Blasius)	Spring 2021
	Orchestration (with Laura Schwendinger)	Spring 2021
	Form and Analysis (with Leslie Blasius)	Spring-Fall 2020
	Schopenhauer and Nietzsche (with James Messina)	Spring 2020
	Existentialism (with Henry Southgate)	Fall 2019

PROFESSIONAL SERVICE	Program Committee	2022 – 2023
	Faculty Colloquium at University of Texas at Austin	
	Conference Organizer, Peer Reviewer	2023
	Graduate Conference at University of Texas at Austin	
PROFESSIONAL AFFILIATIONS	American Society for Aesthetics	2023 – Present
	American Philosophical Association	2023 – Present
LANGUAGES	Mandarin (native), English (fluent)	
REFERENCES	Kathleen M. Higgins	Jon E. Litland
	University of Texas at Austin	University of Texas at Austin
	kmhiggins@austin.utexas.edu	jon.litland@utexas.edu
	Robbie Kubala	Nicole Smith (Teaching)
	University of Texas at Austin	Associate Professor of Instruction
	rkubala@gmail.com	nasmith@austin.utexas.edu
DISSERTATION ABSTRACT	My dissertation is an interdisciplinary project lying at intersections of metaphysics, aesthetics, and music. It consists of a series of papers proceeding in two complementary directions. The first goes from metaphysics to aesthetics, especially to the philosophy of music. I set out and defend a <i>compositional</i> ontology of music, moving away from focusing on the notion of musical <i>works</i>, which is historically contingent and practice-relative. I analyze music as generated from fundamental elements (such as pitches and rhythms) via compositional operations. This framework reveals that the nature of musical objects (and of <i>music</i> by extension) at least partially overlap with mathematical objects/structures. Such shared nature sheds new light, not just on musical ontology, but on musical meaning and representation as well. The second direction goes from music to metaphysics. By drawing insights from musical analysis and applying them in addressing questions about structures and abstraction, I demonstrate that thinking about music itself enriches metaphysical inquiries more generally. A fruitful result from this direction is a general theory of generativism, where I synthesize essentialist and structuralist approaches, arguing that generative operations, whether in music or mathematics, are characterized by certain structural constraints. This unified theory explains how the ‘paradigmatically abstract’ objects, from natural numbers to musical forms, are introduced into our ontology and have their identities explained in terms of the process by which they are generated.	